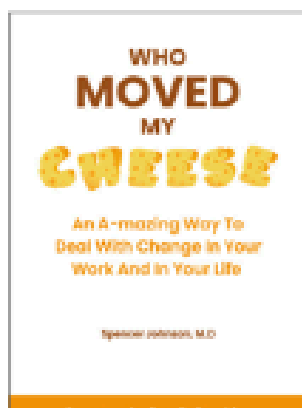




WHO MOVED MY CHEESE?

An A-Mazing Way to Deal with Change
in Your Work and in Your Life

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The Big “So What”

Change is inevitable, yet most people are uncomfortable with it. Through a simple story, **this book illustrates how people react to change, and how we can manage change more constructively and effectively.** The story provides useful metaphors for us to reflect about our own lives, and the ideas can be used to facilitate discussions and shift attitudes toward change.



Introduction

The story is set in a Maze, and provides an analogy to change in our work and personal lives:

- Cheese represents what we want in life, e.g. a successful career, money, health, freedom, spiritual growth etc.
- The Maze represents our complex world (with blind corners and dark areas), where we try to find our way in search of Cheese.
- The 4 characters represent the 4 types of people we encounter in any change situation. The 2 mice (Sniff and Scurry) keep things simple and cope better with change, while the 2 littlepeople (Hem and Haw) tend to overcomplicate things.

The book is written in 3 sections: “A Gathering” of ex-classmates, “The Story”, and “A Discussion” as the classmates reflect on what the story means to them.

In this summary, we'll start by presenting an outline of the story, followed by the key lessons on change.

KEY QUOTES

“Finding Cheese was the littlepeople’s way of getting what they thought they needed to be happy. They had their own ideas of what Cheese meant to them, depending on their taste.”

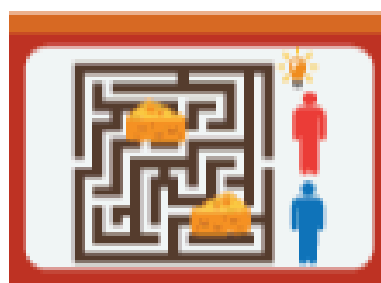


The Story

The fable is set in a maze, where the 2 mice (Sniff and Scurry) and 2 littlepeople (Hem and Haw) look for Cheese every day. Cheese has different significance for the 2 mice (who just like to nibble it) compared to the 2 littlepeople (who need Cheese to feel happy and successful).

Each day, the mice and littlepeople leave their respective homes and race into the maze to look for Cheese.

- Sniff and Scurry use trial-and-error, remembering the wrong turns and exploring new areas. Sniff depends more on his nose while Scurry dashes around quickly.
- The littlepeople also learn from their experiences, but they develop more sophisticated ways to find Cheese.
- Eventually, they all find "Cheese Station C", with a large stash of Cheese!

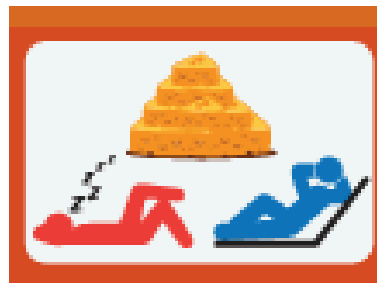


Having found Cheese, both the mice and littlepeople now go straight from their homes to Station C every day to enjoy the Cheese.

- Sniff and Scurry continue to wake up early in the morning, race to the station, inspect the area, then enjoy the Cheese.
- Hem and Haw start out with a similar routine. Over time, they begin to believe that the Cheese will always be there, so they wake up later and stroll over to Station C at their leisure. They don't know how the Cheese got there or who replenishes it, but they think of the Cheese as *theirs*. After all, didn't they work hard to find it? They feel content, secure and successful. They move their homes closer to Station C and even decorate the place. Occasionally, they invite their friends over to show off the Cheese, and to give them a treat.

KEY QUOTES

"Sometimes (the littlepeople) did well, but at other times their powerful human beliefs and emotions took over and clouded the way they looked at things."



As time passes, Sniff and Scurry notice that the supply of Cheese is decreasing. One morning, they arrive to find that there's no more Cheese.

- Since the situation has changed, the mice do the obvious – they change too. They immediately go back into the Maze, in search of new Cheese.
- After scouring the maze for some time, the mice eventually find "Cheese Station N", with an even larger stash and variety of New Cheese.



Hem and Haw, on the other hand, are so comfortable with their seemingly-endless supply of Cheese that they don't notice the decreasing supply. When they arrive later that day, they're stunned.

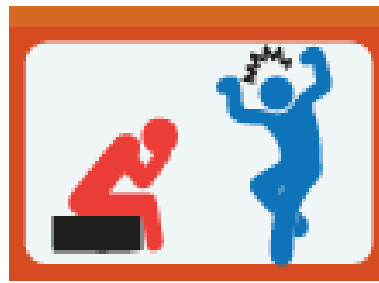
- Hem keeps yelling and shouting, "Who moved my Cheese?!" and laments how unfair it is. Haw just freezes in shock and disbelief. The Cheese means so much to them, that they dread to think of what would happen without it.
- They keep looking around Station C, returning day after day in hope that the Cheese will somehow show up again. Each day, they fret and worry about their future, feeling upset at the injustice of their Cheese being taken away.
- They rationalize that if they work harder to search around Station C, and use new tools to improve their search, they'll find Cheese.

KEY QUOTES

"The mice did not overanalyze things."

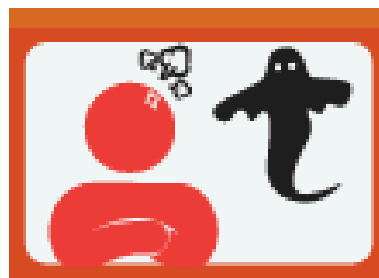
"The littlepeople's behaviour was not very attractive or productive but it was understandable."

"The more important your cheese is to you the more you want to hold on to it."



With each passing day, Hem and Haw get progressively weaker, more stressed and afraid to leave Station C.

- Haw finally realizes that being busy isn't going to change anything. He starts to consider leaving Station C to search for more Cheese.
- Hem refuses. He's still angry about how unfair things are. He talks about the dangers in the Maze, how old he is, etc. He doesn't want to fail.
- To make himself feel better about venturing out again into the Maze, Haw imagines himself stepping out with a smile, and visualizes realistic details of what it's like to find New Cheese and to taste it. He laughs at himself, and immediately feels better about letting go and moving on to find New Cheese. He finally gets enough courage to leave Station C.



However, searching for New Cheese isn't easy.

- The Maze has changed, and Haw keeps getting lost.
- He's constantly disappointed to discover a potential Cheese station, only to find it empty, or with leftover bits of Cheese and crumbs.
- He almost gives up, but reminds himself that he's at least taking control of the situation. He asks himself, "what would I do if I wasn't afraid?", focuses on the mental picture of finding New Cheese, and keeps going. As he overcomes his fears and moves ahead with faith, he starts to feel a new sense of freedom.

KEY QUOTES

"Haw was beginning to realize the difference between activity and productivity."

"Sometimes... things change and they are never the same again... Life moves on. And so should we."

"When you move beyond your fear, you feel free."

- Along the way, Haw reflects on the situation and writes down his learnings and insights on the walls, both as a reminder to himself, and to leave a trail for Hem to follow if he chooses to leave Station C.



As Haw gains courage, he ventures into newer parts of the Maze, and finds new types of Cheese that he has never tried before.

- Haw brings back some New Cheese for Hem, but Hem refuses to try it. Hem is sure he won't like New Cheese; He only wants Old Cheese.
- Haw continues his search, confident that he'd eventually find New Cheese. The bits of Cheese that he finds along the way help to sustain him. With more energy and confidence, he starts to enjoy the process, and tries more new routes.
- Finally, Haw finds Station N. As Haw savours the New Cheese at Station N together with Sniff and Scurry, he continues to apply the lessons that he has learnt. Now, he examines the station for signs of change daily, so he won't be caught by surprise. He also spends part of his time exploring the Maze to stay in touch with the outside world.



- Haw contemplates returning to look for Hem, but realizes that Hem has to help himself by deciding to change first. Haw can only hope that the writings on the wall will help Hem to find his way.

KEY QUOTES

"Haw realized he had been held captive by his own fear. Moving in a new direction had freed him."

"He was letting go and trusting what lay ahead for him, even though he did not know exactly what it was."

"The quicker you let go of old cheese, the sooner you find new cheese."

"A change imposed is a change opposed."



Change: Reflections and Lessons



The 4 characters in the story mirror our common responses to change. Consider: which character are you like?

- Sniff is able to sniff out the situation and uncover changes early;
- Scurry moves quickly into action;
- Haw learns to adapt and make changes for better outcomes; and
- Hem denies change and prefers to stay in his comfort zone rather than deal with reality.



What are the Cheeses in your life? “Cheese” means different things to different people, e.g. a happy family, successful career, or spiritual growth. Still, every Cheese eventually runs out, and there’s always New Cheese out there.

- Often, we may think that our Old Cheese is our only Cheese, and we hang on to it, e.g. an old business model, an old group of customers, or an old relationship. Ask yourself: What Old Cheese are you hanging on to?
- Consider the changes you can make in both your work and personal life. For example, how can you let go of bad behaviours and refresh a stale relationship, and what New Cheese can you find together with your spouse?
- In fact, rather than wait for the Cheese to run out, you can explore moving your own Cheese. For example, you can take proactive steps to transform old store concepts that aren't working, and try out fresh ideas rather than wait to take action only when new competition arrives on the scene.



Change is inevitable, and is happening all the time, whether you like it or not. In short, the Cheese will keep moving. Rather than be caught by surprise, expect change, and learn to move with it, over and over again.



Stay Vigilant. There are always hints of impending change. Be

KEY QUOTES

“When you change what you believe, you change what you do.”

“Sometimes we’re not even aware that we’re afraid.”

“It’s a lot better to initiate change while you can than it is to try to react and adjust to it.”

“Change could surprise you only if you didn’t expect it and weren’t looking for it.”

on the look out for small changes, so you're better prepared for the bigger changes to come. Haw realizes on hindsight that, before the Cheese at Station C "disappeared", it was already dropping in quantity, and was starting to smell and taste stale. Had he been alert, he would not have been caught by surprise.

 **Adapt Quickly.** There is always New Cheese out in the Maze.

- The faster you let go of your Old Cheese, the sooner you can find and enjoy New Cheese.
- In fact, if you wait too long, you may be too late and become extinct. People who are unaware of changing job requirements, or are unwilling to adapt, may find themselves being fired or laid off. Many established business that refuse to accept changes have also become obsolete.



Overcome Fear. Keep things simple like Sniff and Scurry, so you can change and shift easily. Don't overanalyze things and become paralyzed by fear.

- Often, we're in denial or are unaware of our own fears. Ask yourself, "What would I do if I wasn't afraid?"
- Learn to laugh at yourself and your mistakes. Have fun and enjoy the adventure.
- Focus on the New Cheese you can gain, rather than the Old Cheese you have lost or can lose.



Leading Change. Instead of trying to cope with the rat race and manage your workload, consciously plan for and lead change.

- Paint a vivid picture of the New Cheese and share it with your team.
- Manage all 4 types of characters: (i) Use *Sniffs* to identify changes, (ii) use *Scurrys* to get things done with guidance, (iii) help *Haws* to overcome their initial scepticism, embrace the vision and open up to new possibilities, and (iv) convert *Hems* to *Haws* through a clear vision and showing them how others are also making the change. However, there'll always be some *Hems* who choose to play victims and blame others, and you should be prepared to let them go.

KEY QUOTES

"Noticing small changes early helps you to adapt to the bigger changes that are to come."

"Smell the cheese often so you know when it is getting old."

"What you are afraid of is never as bad as what you imagine."

"The fastest way to change is to laugh at your own folly - then you can let go and quickly move on."

"When you see how it can make things better, you get more interested in making the change happen."

"The biggest inhibitor to change lies within yourself, and... nothing gets better until you change."

- Share this story to facilitate discussions about change (e.g. which character(s) people relate to, what are their Old vs New Cheese), and shift attitudes toward change (no one wants to be Hem!).



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

This is a short and easy to read story, that can be easily shared with others. For more details, training and learning product information, please visit www.whomovedmycheese.com.

About the Author

Spencer Johnson, MD is one of the most admired thought leaders and widely-read authors in the world. Called "The King of Parables" by USA Today, Dr. Johnson is an expert in taking complex subjects and presenting simple solutions that work. Besides his book, he is also the co-author of best-selling book, "The New One-Minute Manager".



His brief books contain insights and practical tools that millions of people use to enjoy more happiness and success with less stress. For more details, visit, www.spencerjohnson.com.

KEY QUOTES